



2026 EDITION · PET COST DATA SUMMARY

The real cost of owning a pet.

The honest numbers — by breed, by region — so you can welcome your new family member with total confidence, not guesswork.

300+

breeds covered

3

countries: US, UK & AU

June 2026

data updated

Getting a dog or cat is one of the best decisions you'll ever make — and it should be one of the most informed. This guide cuts through the guesswork and gives you real numbers you can plan around.

An honest guide — from one pet lover to another.

WELCOME

First, the honest truth about cost.

Why we made this guide — and how to get the most from it.

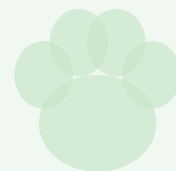
Nearly half of new pet owners — 41% — told us the first year cost more than they expected. Not because pets are extravagant, but because the real costs are spread across dozens of small line items that nobody adds up in advance: the crate and the carrier, the desexing, the microchip, the first round of vaccinations, the food you didn't realise they'd get through.

This guide adds them up for you. Inside, you'll find first-year and lifetime costs for 25 popular breeds, a clear breakdown of where the money actually goes, how costs shift depending on where you live, and a straight-talking look at pet insurance — what it covers, what it doesn't, and when it genuinely pays for itself.

None of this is meant to put you off. Quite the opposite. A pet you've planned for is a pet you can relax and enjoy — no nasty surprises, no difficult decisions made under financial pressure. Think of these numbers as the foundation for a long, happy life together.

“The best time to understand the cost of a pet is before you bring them home.”

— The PetCost team

**WHAT'S INSIDE**[Key findings](#)[Breed cost tables](#)[Where the money goes](#)[Cost by city](#)[Insurance decoded](#)[Money-saving playbook](#)[Readiness checklist](#)

KEY FINDINGS 2026

What you're really signing up for.

The numbers behind the love — six findings that shape every budget.

+12%

Vet costs rose last year

Veterinary fees climbed 12% in 2025 — four points ahead of inflation. Emergency and specialist care rose fastest.

\$3,847

Average first-year cost, medium dog

Covers adoption or purchase, food, vet visits, basic training, bedding, toys and 12 months of insurance.

\$2,190

Average first-year cost, cat

Cats are cheaper to set up — but ongoing vet and food costs sit closer to dogs than most people expect.

41%

Underestimated year-one costs

Nearly half of new owners were surprised by the first-year total. This guide exists so you're not one of them.

\$1,823

Average unexpected vet bill

A single accident or illness can wipe out months of savings — the core reason insurance earns its keep.

68%

Of insured pets claimed in 2025

More than two in three insured pets needed to claim last year. Cover is the rule, not the exception.

Remember these are averages. Your costs depend on breed, age, health and location — use the calculator for a figure that's actually yours.

DOG BREEDS

What a dog really costs.

First-year, annual and lifetime cost for 15 popular breeds (US national average).

Breed	Year 1	Annual (yr 2+)	Lifetime (12 yr)
French Bulldog Small	\$5,800	\$3,200	\$40,800
English Bulldog Medium	\$5,400	\$3,100	\$39,100
German Shepherd Large	\$4,200	\$2,600	\$33,400
Golden Retriever Large	\$3,900	\$2,400	\$30,300
Poodle (Standard) Large	\$3,800	\$2,500	\$31,500
Labrador Retriever Large	\$3,700	\$2,300	\$29,300
Siberian Husky Large	\$3,500	\$2,400	\$30,400
Cavoodle Small	\$3,200	\$2,200	\$27,200
Shih Tzu Small	\$2,900	\$2,100	\$26,100
Border Collie Medium	\$2,800	\$2,000	\$25,000
Dachshund Small	\$2,500	\$1,900	\$24,100
Beagle Medium	\$2,400	\$1,800	\$22,800
Chihuahua Small	\$2,100	\$1,600	\$20,600
Bernese Mountain Dog Giant	\$4,900	\$2,900	\$36,800
Mixed Breed (rescue) Varies	\$1,900	\$1,700	\$21,700

Year 1 includes adoption/purchase, initial vet and setup. Annual reflects ongoing costs only.

CAT BREEDS

What a cat really costs.

First-year, annual and lifetime cost for 10 popular breeds (US national average).

Breed	Year 1	Annual (yr 2+)	Lifetime (15 yr)
Sphynx	\$3,100	\$2,100	\$34,600
Bengal	\$2,900	\$1,800	\$29,800
Persian	\$2,800	\$1,900	\$30,400
Scottish Fold	\$2,700	\$2,000	\$32,000
Maine Coon	\$2,600	\$1,800	\$29,600
British Shorthair	\$2,400	\$1,700	\$27,200
Siamese	\$2,200	\$1,600	\$25,600
Russian Blue	\$2,100	\$1,500	\$23,600
Ragdoll	\$1,900	\$1,500	\$23,900
Domestic Shorthair	\$1,600	\$1,200	\$19,600

Lifetime based on a 15-year average lifespan. Actual costs vary by individual cat and vet.

Rescue cats are a wonderful option ♥

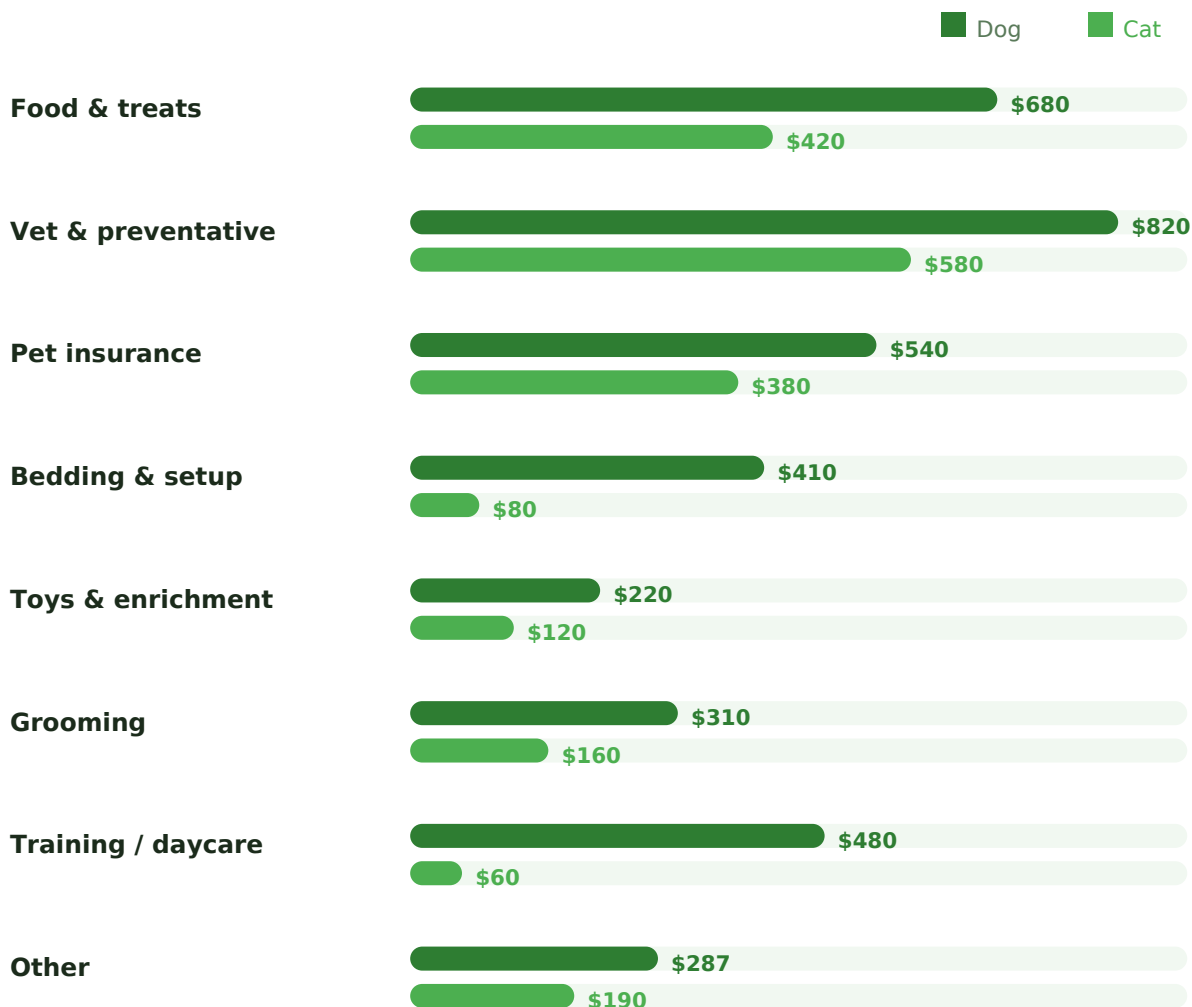
A domestic shorthair from a rescue centre costs a fraction of a pedigree and is just as loving — often more so. Adoption fees usually cover vaccinations, microchipping and desexing, saving you hundreds in first-year vet costs.



WHERE IT GOES

Where does the money actually go?

Year-one cost breakdown for a typical medium dog and cat.



Total year one

Dog \$3,747

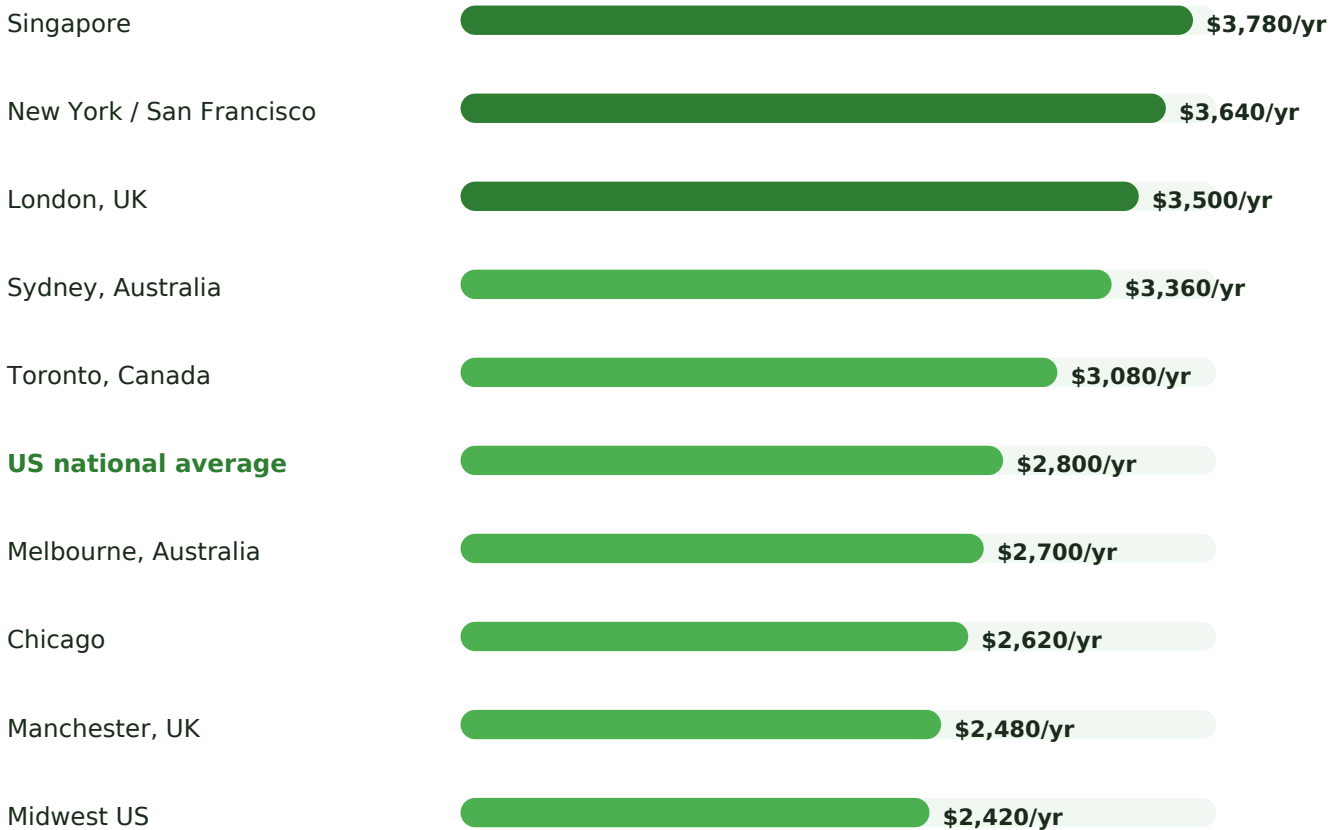
Cat \$1,990

After year one, setup costs fall away — your ongoing annual cost is noticeably lower.

LOCATION

Where you live matters — a lot.

Annual cost for a medium dog by city (ongoing, excludes year-one setup).



Local-currency costs shown as USD equivalents. Vet and grooming drive most of the variation.

Pro tip for city dwellers

Insurance saves the most in high-cost cities — a vet bill in NYC or Sydney can be 3x a rural one. If you're in a major metro, budget at least 10% above the national average.

INSURANCE

Pet insurance — your safety net.

What it covers, what it costs, and why 68% of insured pets claimed last year.

Accident only

\$20-40 /mo

COVERS

- ✓ Injuries & accidents
- ✓ Emergency vet
- ✓ Surgery from injury

USUALLY EXCLUDES

- ✗ Illness
- ✗ Dental
- ✗ Preventative care

MOST POPULAR

Accident + illness

\$40-70 /mo

COVERS

- ✓ Everything in Accident
- ✓ Most illnesses
- ✓ Cancer treatment
- ✓ Hereditary conditions

USUALLY EXCLUDES

- ✗ Dental
- ✗ Preventative care

Comprehensive

\$70-120 /mo

COVERS

- ✓ Everything in A+I
- ✓ Dental care
- ✓ Preventative visits
- ✓ Alternative therapy

USUALLY EXCLUDES

- ✗ Cosmetic
- ✗ Pre-existing conditions

The one thing most people miss

Every policy has a waiting period (usually 14-30 days). Buy cover before you need it — not after your pet gets sick.

EXTREMES

The big spenders & best value.

Five most expensive and five most affordable — and why.

Most expensive breeds

- 1 French Bulldog** **\$5,800 yr 1**
 Brachycephalic breathing, skin and spinal issues mean frequent vet visits.
- 2 English Bulldog** **\$5,400 yr 1**
 Similar breathing problems plus joint issues and specialised food.
- 3 Chow Chow** **\$5,100 yr 1**
 Professional grooming is non-negotiable, plus several hereditary conditions.
- 4 Bernese Mountain Dog** **\$4,900 yr 1**
 Giant-size food bills and sadly high cancer rates late in life.
- 5 Tibetan Mastiff** **\$4,700 yr 1**
 One of the largest breeds — food alone tops \$1,000/yr; rare specialists.

Best value breeds

- 1 Chihuahua** **\$2,100 yr 1**
 Small, hardy and inexpensive to feed, with few grooming needs.
- 2 Mixed Breed (rescue)** **\$1,900 yr 1**
 Hybrid vigour means fewer hereditary issues; adoption covers early vet care.
- 3 Domestic Shorthair** **\$1,600 yr 1**
 The most affordable cat — healthy, low-maintenance and widely available.
- 4 Beagle** **\$2,400 yr 1**
 Moderate everything: food, grooming and generally robust health.
- 5 Ragdoll Cat** **\$1,900 yr 1**
 Relaxed, low-grooming temperament keeps ongoing costs gentle.

SAVE SMARTER

The money-saving playbook.

Eight ways to cut the cost of pet ownership — without cutting any corners.

1**Insure early, before problems start**

Premiums are lowest and exclusions fewest when your pet is young and healthy. Wait, and any condition that appears becomes 'pre-existing' — and uninsurable.

2**Build a \$1,500+ emergency fund**

Insurance has deductibles and waiting periods. A cash buffer covers the gap and the excess, so you're never forced into a hard decision.

3**Adopt instead of shop**

Rescue fees of \$150-\$400 typically include vaccinations, microchip and desexing — saving hundreds against a breeder's first-year vet costs.

4**Buy food in bulk & subscribe**

Auto-ship and large bags cut food costs 15-25%. Food is 40-50% of the annual bill, so this is the single biggest lever.

5**Never skip preventative care**

Annual checks, dental and parasite control are cheap. Skipping them risks four-figure bills later — preventative care cuts emergencies by up to 30%.

6**Learn basic grooming at home**

Brushing, nail trims and bathing between professional visits can halve grooming costs for coat-heavy breeds.

7**Compare insurance every renewal**

Prices vary up to 40% between providers for identical cover. A 20-minute comparison at renewal routinely saves \$100+/yr.

8**Right-size the breed to your budget**

Size drives food, medication and boarding costs. Choosing a breed that fits your finances is the biggest saving of all.

SELF-CHECK

Am I ready for a pet?

A quick gut-check for your head — and your heart. (A fillable version is in your pack.)

Financial readiness

- ☐ I can comfortably cover year-one costs without financial stress
- ☐ I have, or will get, pet insurance before bringing my pet home
- ☐ I have an emergency fund of at least \$1,500 for unexpected vet bills
- ☐ I've budgeted for annual check-ups, vaccinations and parasite control
- ☐ I've researched boarding or pet-sitting costs for when I travel

Lifestyle fit

- ☐ My home suits a pet — space, outdoor access and rental rules allow it
- ☐ I have time to give a dog 2+ hours of exercise and attention daily
- ☐ I've planned for my pet's care if I need to work away or travel
- ☐ I've matched the breed's energy and temperament to my lifestyle
- ☐ Everyone in my household is genuinely on board

Long-term commitment

- ☐ I'm ready for a 10–15 year commitment, through life changes
- ☐ I've thought through moving, children or a change of job
- ☐ I've researched breed-specific health issues for my chosen breed

METHODOLOGY

How we calculated this.

Our sources, our assumptions, and where to go from here.

Data sources

Cost data is compiled from vet-clinic surveys across the US, UK and Australia; pet-insurance claim data; current retail pricing for food, supplies and grooming; and breed-specific health research from veterinary associations.

What first-year costs include

Adoption or purchase fee, initial vet visit (vaccinations, microchip, health check), desexing, bedding, collar/harness/lead, crate or carrier, first food and supplies, and a 12-month insurance premium.

What annual costs include

From year two onward we exclude one-time setup items. The annual figure reflects what a typical year looks like once your pet is settled — food, routine vet care, grooming, insurance and supplies.

A note on averages

Every figure here is an indicative average. Your real costs depend on your location, the individual animal, and the choices you make. Treat these numbers as a confident starting point — then make them yours.

Ready to see your pet's real numbers?

Get a personalised estimate in under 2 minutes — choose your breed, [petcost-calculator.com/calculator](#) full breakdown.

